Market study — Nhill in Kinshasa (DRC)

Français : ../fr/01-etude-marche.md

Version	2.0.0 — 27 October 2026
Area	Kinshasa first, then Lubumbashi and Goma
Method	desk research (sources § 8), no field survey specific to Nhill; figures are those of the sources, with their dates
Limitation	no market figure was invented; where data is missing, the document says how to obtain it

1. Summary

- Congolese micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) are getting equipped: in a survey of 914 MSMEs (Kinshasa, Goma, Lubumbashi), **51 %** use digital tools, **46 %** of micro-enterprises and **71 %** of small ones [S2].
- Among equipped MSMEs, **94 %** use a smartphone, **86 %** a laptop, **72 %** accounting software, but only **19 %** stock management software [S2]: sales, stock and till management is the poorly equipped link — Nhill's space.
- **Cost** is the first barrier cited (54 % of micro-enterprises) [S2]; connectivity and energy follow (regular power cuts for 16 % of MSMEs, 33 % without backup) [S2]. Nhill must be affordable, light on data and tolerant of outages.
- Country digital access: 114 million people, 34.7 million Internet users (30.5 %), 64.7 million mobile connections (56.9 % of the population), 10.4 million social-media identities, 48.8 % urban (October 2025 data) [S1].
- **Decisive regulatory constraint**: VAT payers must issue standardised invoices with software or a device certified by the DGI (penalties announced from 15 May 2026) [S4]. Nhill is not certified. The first market is therefore **businesses not registered for VAT** and **management** uses (stock, till, per-employee tracking) alongside the tax device for VAT payers.

2. The problem observed

Finding	Source	What Nhill brings
Low use of stock management (19 % of equipped MSMEs)	S2	stock through movements, threshold alerts, stock-take, history with author
Cost, the first barrier	S2	subscription per business, free trial, free pilot; prices set after the pilot
Power and Internet cuts	S2	resume without double entry after a cut, light desktop application, Android
Hiring by word of mouth (79 % of MSMEs): trusted, informal teams	S2	one account per person, non-modifiable activity log, "blind" till closing
31 % of sampled MSMEs not registered with the RCCM	S2	can start without legal identifiers, add them later
Massive mobile use	S1, S2	Nhill Business on Android, phone-friendly screens

3. Segments

Segment	Description	Interest for Nhill	Priority
A. Non-VAT retail shops (Gombe, Limete, Ngaliema, Kintambo, organised markets)	1–5 people, one till, a few hundred items	till + stock + staff tracking; quick decision by the owner	**1**
B. Hardware stores, building-material depots, wholesalers	large stock, credit sales, several sellers	stock, customer receivables, supplier purchases	**1**
C. Pharmacies and parapharmacies (no prescriptions)	many items, till control	till, stock, thresholds	2
D. Service providers (workshops, printers, agencies)	quotes and invoices, little stock	quotes → invoices, payments	2
E. VAT-registered SMEs	must use the DGI device	Nhill alongside (stock, till, reports), not for the standardised invoice	3 — after tax clarification

4. Competition and alternatives

Alternative	Strengths	Weaknesses for the target	Nhill's position
Notebook, receipt book, calculator	free, familiar, no equipment	no reliable stock, no seller control, errors	same simplicity, with control
Spreadsheet (Excel)	flexible, already installed	no traceability, lost files, not multi-user	data on a server, one account per person
International management software (online ERP)	feature-rich, integrations	prices in foreign currency, complexity, little adapted to local French and CDF	simple, CDF and USD, French and English, local support
Local till software	local presence, installers	often single-computer, little remote control	multi-device, remote viewing, activity log
DGI-certified software and devices	compliant for the standardised invoice	focused on tax compliance	complementary (Nhill does not replace the standardised invoice)

Competitors' public prices change and depend on regions: record them from their websites on the day of the pricing decision (watch table in `trackers/`), never from memory.

5. Value proposition

> **Nhill: your sales, stock and till, clear — even when you're not in the shop.**

Three benefits, verifiable in the software:

1. **Know what sells and what's left**: every sale lowers stock; alerts warn before running out.
2. **Know who did what**: one account per employee, a log nobody can erase, a till closing where the cashier doesn't see the expected amount.
3. **Work despite outages**: an interrupted operation can be retried without being recorded twice.

Never say: "DGI-compliant", "standardised invoice", "certified", "fully offline" (Nhill needs a connection to record), "bug-free", unmeasured gains.

6. Pricing (to set after the pilot)

No price is set (website, “Access and pricing” page). Proposed method:

1. During the pilot, measure time saved and differences avoided at each pilot.
2. Ask pilots about their current spending (stationery, spreadsheet, software) and an acceptable price (end-of-pilot questionnaire).
3. Record the public prices of alternatives (§ 4) on the same date.
4. Set 2 or 3 plans (users, tills, warehouses) in CDF and USD, with a published, dated conversion rate (official BCC rate).

Exchange reference for the budgets in this file: **1 USD = 2,264.0000 CDF**, official rate of the Central Bank of the Congo on **26/10/2026** [S3].

7. Estimating market size (to do, without inventing)

The number of target businesses in Kinshasa was not found in a reliable source. Method:

Step	Source to consult	Expected result
1	Business-creation one-stop shop, Kinshasa RCCM: registrations by form and sector	formal businesses
2	Fédération des entreprises du Congo (FEC), traders’ associations	breakdown by sector and size
3	Field count on 3 shopping streets per segment (A, B, C)	shops per street
4	Share equipped with a computer or Android tablet (prospecting questionnaire)	addressable market
5	Pilot conversion rate	reachable market at 12 months

8. Sources

Ref.	Source	Date
S1	DataReportal — Digital 2026: The Democratic Republic of the Congo	published 8 November 2025, October 2025 data
S2	Malabar, Innogence Consulting, King Baudouin Foundation — “Transformation digitale en RDC : état des lieux des MPME”; presentation: King Baudouin Foundation	April 2025; fieldwork 16 October 2024 – 14 January 2025; 914 MSMEs (Kinshasa 270, Goma 334, Lubumbashi 270), **non-representative sample** according to the authors
S3	Central Bank of the Congo — official exchange rate	26/10/2026: 1 USD = 2,264.0000 CDF
S4	DGI — standardised invoice reform; La Prospérité — penalties from 15 May 2026	consulted 26/10/2026
S5	GSMA — State of the Industry Report on Mobile Money 2026: Sub-Saharan Africa 2025, 1.2 billion registered accounts, 341 million 30-day active accounts, USD 1.4 trillion transactions (no DRC-specific figure)	2026

Data consulted on 26 and 27 October 2026.